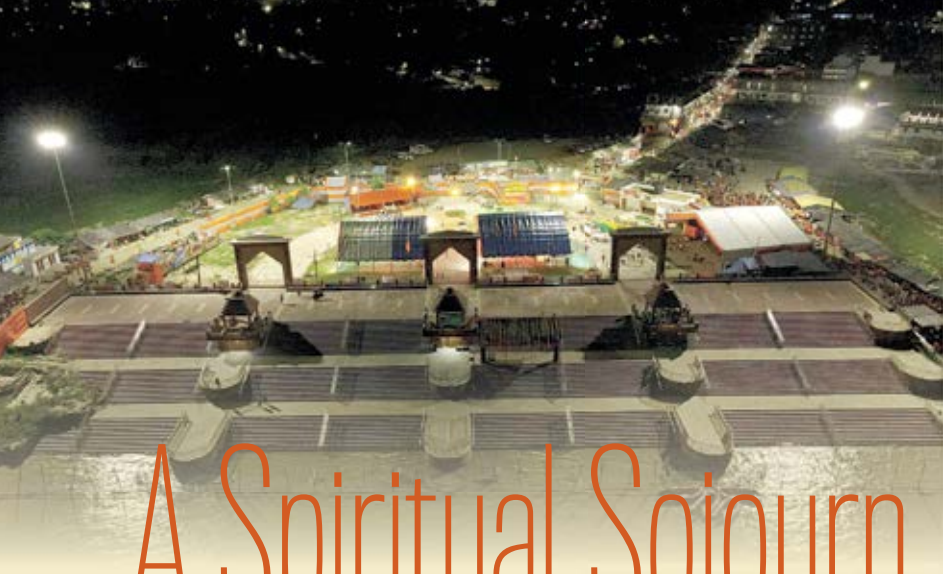


A Spiritual Sojourn

Bihar is an ancient land suffused with the deep aura of spirituality. Besides being the birthplace of Buddhism, it is also home to ancient fairs and rituals associated with Hinduism since time immemorial.

One of the most popular fairs is the annual Shravani Mela which draws thousands of devout to Deoghar in the month of Shravan. This year, this month-long celebration, said to be one of the world's longest religious fairs, will be observed from 22 July to 19 August.

The mela sees lakhs of kanwariyas collect holy water from the Uttarvahini Ganga (north-flowing Ganga) in Sultanganj and walk 105 kilometres to Baidyanath Dham in Deoghar where they offer it to Baba Baidyanath or Lord Shiva. The entire route has an air of celebration about it, with the administration making excellent arrangements for the comfort and safety of the pilgrims. While there is a much-revered and established route between Sultanganj and Deoghar, to deal with the huge influx of devotees, the Government of Bihar has developed two more routes, via Munger and Baanka.

Sultanganj, the starting point for the Shravani Mela, is situated in the Bhagalpur district, 25 km west of Bhagalpur city on the Ganga's south bank. Pilgrims from all over the world converge on this sacred site to begin their journey to Baidyanath Dham. Situated next to the Ganga in Sultanganj, the Ajgaivinath Temple is a deeply revered temple dedicated to Lord Shiva. The northward flow of the Ganga here is considered auspicious, and legend says that one of the great sages of antiquity, Jahnu dwelt here. Millions of people visit the ancient Shiva temple in Sultanganj, perched on a hill near the Ganga River.

As the devout walk the holy path, carrying sacred Ganga water on their shoulders while wearing their kanwars, the route resounds with cries of "Bol Bam". The human chain of pilgrims clothed in saffron proceeds steadfastly towards their destination. At Baba Dham, the kanwariyas bathe in the Shivaganga to purify themselves before going into the Baba Baidyanath temple, where the Jyotirlingam is offered the holy Ganga water. Other holy spots that are visited here include the Ramniwas Ashram of Saint Balanand Brahmachari, Mohan Mandir of Mohananand Swami, Kailash Pahar Ashram-Jasidih of Swami Hansdev Avadhoot, as well as the Rikhiya Ashram.











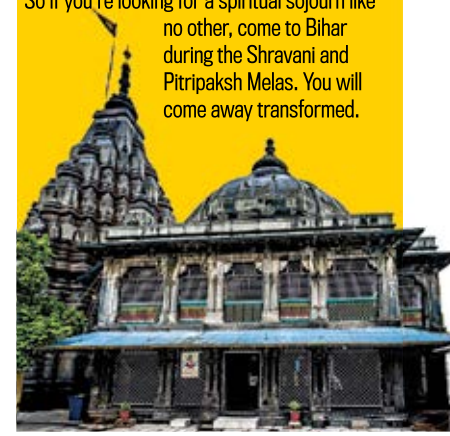




Another holy fair to look forward to a little later in the year is the Pitripaksh Mela held in Punpun and Gaya. This year the mela is being held from 17 September to 2 October. Of course, devout Hindus have been travelling to Gaya to pay obeisance to their ancestors since time immemorial. However, the most propitious time to do so is during Pitripaksh, a time of year dedicated to assuaging the departed souls of ancestors, asking for their forgiveness, and ridding oneself of Pitra Dosha (curse of ancestors). During this period rituals like Shraddh, Tarpan, and Pind Daan are performed to release the departed soul from the cycle of birth, life, and death. Such rituals are performed at the Falgu River in Gaya, after offering special prayers at the Vishnupad Temple.

Another holy location to observe Pitripaksh is the Punpun Ghat near Patna, which is significant for its historical and natural beauty, and for its association with the first Pind Daan, or Shraddh, performed in Hindu Dharma. The Vayu and Padma Puranas also mention the Punpun River in connection with Gaya Mahatmya, and interpret the word "punah-punah" (again and again) in a spiritual sense. They say that offering oblations to ancestors in this river removes all sins.

So if you're looking for a spiritual sojourn like no other, come to Bihar during the Shravani and Pitripaksh Melas. You will come away transformed.



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